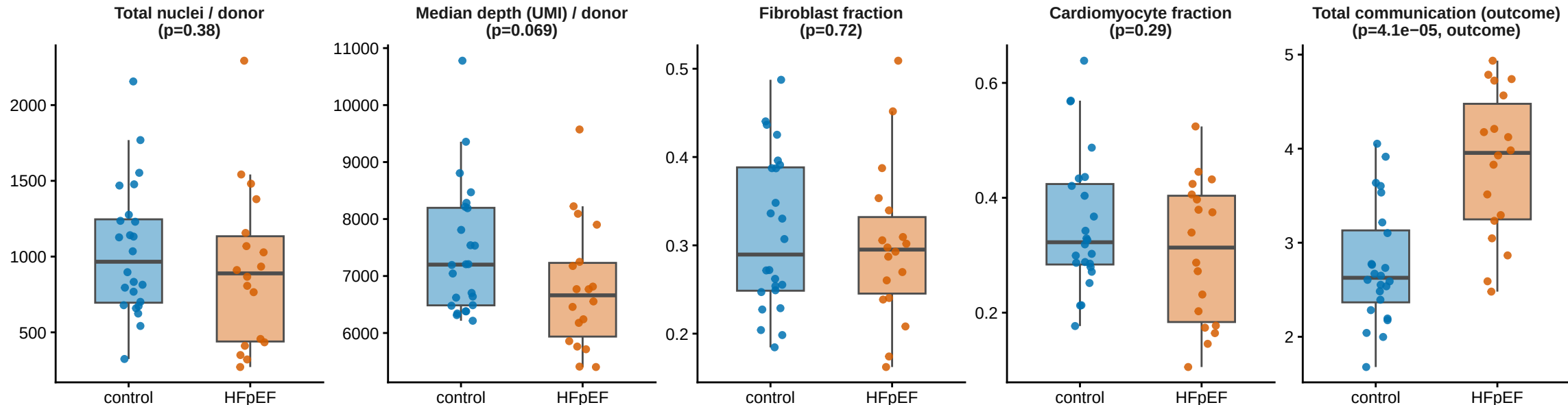


Per-donor technical & compositional balance (Step 3 confound check)

First four = balance checks (expect ns). Last = total communication (outcome, expected to differ).



Each point = one donor. Median depth trends LOWER in HFpEF ($p=0.069$, Cliff's $d=-0.33$); since detection / communication are HIGHER despite lower depth, this bias is conservative (against the finding). Any significant balance metric is shown honestly and carried as a limitation.